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ENTERPRISE



Upwork is buying its way
into corporate staffing
beyond freelancers

Upwork, a platform that connects companies with freelancers, announced two acquisitions to help build out a new stand-alone enterprise-focused business that could expand its market reach.

The San Francisco-based company announced it has acquired **Bubty**, a workforce management platform, and has signed a definitive agreement to acquire **Ascen**, a global compliance and EOR (employer of record) company, ahead of its second-quarter earnings call on August 6.

Upwork will integrate these two companies into its existing enterprise business to create a stand-alone entity under the Upwork umbrella.

The move is significant because it will allow Upwork to offer access to talent beyond the independent contractor workforce Upwork is known for — essentially enabling the company to compete in new areas of the corporate staffing market. The new entity will support contract types, including agent of record, employer of record, and staff augmentation.

Upwork president and CEO Hayden Brown told TechCrunch that the timing was right to launch this new enterprise-focused business because Upwork's existing enterprise customers have been increasingly asking for access to these talent pools.

"Most of the providers that exist today force their customers to choose between flexibility and compliance, or speed and scale, or having a digital tool versus having something that's actually robust and for the enterprise," Brown said. "And with this new capability, we're refusing to compromise. We're giving our customers all of the benefits they've been looking for, and we've heard loud and clear that they want this singular solution."

Brown said that Upwork's existing enterprise business makes up about \$100 million of the company's overall \$750 million in yearly revenue.

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Upwork decided to make the enterprise business a stand-alone entity because enterprises have very different needs regarding compliance and software integrations than the small and midsize businesses Upwork's main business works with.

Keeping them separate allows for better external branding and better internal focus, Brown said.

Upwork vetted more than 100 potential companies to acquire to build out this business, Brown said. The company landed on Buby and Ascen not only for what they bring separately but also for how they worked together — Upwork piloted the companies both individually and together.

"We saw through the power of those pilots how impactful their technology was and how easy it was to basically snap together what each of them offers, along with our existing offering to deliver something very new and innovative in the market," Brown added.

Details on the branding and full offerings of the new stand-alone business are set to be unveiled later this year.

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Another new survey underscores that skilled workers can pretty much live wherever they want

Connie Loizos — 8:22 AM PST · March 9, 2018

If you want to live outside an expensive city like San Francisco or New York, it pays to have specialized knowledge. So suggests a [new survey](#) out of [Upwork](#), the freelancing platform created from the 2013 merger of Elance and oDesk that connects businesses and independent contractors.

According to feedback from more than 1,005 workforce hiring decision-makers conducted on Upwork’s behalf by the company [ClearlyRated](#), skilled workers can pretty much live wherever they want and employers will come to them. The reason: companies say they are struggling to find talent, with the average position open for 36 days and some engineering jobs vacant for up to 45 days.

In fact, though the majority of organizations surveyed — 57 percent — don’t support a work-from-home policy, those that do say they’ve become increasingly inclusive of people who work outside the office, and five times as many hiring managers expect more of their team to work remotely in the next decade than expect less. Put simply, they say the most skilled person for the job outweighs that person’s ability to work in the same location as the rest of the team.

The survey’s findings aren’t a huge surprise for a number of reasons, including that it’s in Upwork’s interests to promote the idea that freelancing is where it’s at. (The more freelancers it has to choose from, the better for its platform.)

It’s also the case that mobility has slowed dramatically, with slightly more than one in ten Americans (11.2 percent) moving between 2015 and 2016 — roughly [half the rate](#) that it was 60 years ago, when the Census began tracking American mobility. In some situations, people simply can’t move, particularly in cases where their homes act as a kind of tether. But many more are choosing not to move, including because the cost of living is higher elsewhere and because they are finding job opportunities where they are.

That’s especially true if they’re more educated. A [separate workforce study](#) — also published recently by a flexible-hiring company, also in concert with an independent third party — reported that telecommuting is most common among management positions, with professional, scientific and technical services industries featuring the highest percentage of telecommuters relative to their share of the workforce.

It isn’t a trend that looks to wane, says Upwork CEO Stephane Kasriel. “People aren’t just doing this and saying they’d go back to traditional hiring if they could. Looking out over the next ten years at least, it’s clear that this is the new normal. Roughly 38 percent of full-time workers will be working remotely by 2027.”

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Workers “want to do this,” says Kasriel. And “in the current labor market, skilled workers have their way.”

Interestingly, Kasriel argues that “city planners aren’t thinking sufficiently” about the shape of workforces and how they are evolving. He believes cities will be organized differently as a result.

That’s something he shares in common with renowned investor Peter Thiel. Talking last fall at a conference in Saudi Arabia, Thiel suggested that an underrated trend that merits far more attention is telecommuting and how its rise will [change the physical landscape](#). Said Thiel, “The transportation-related technology that I wonder about more than self-driving cars is, is there some way to do an end run around our broken transportation systems, and the IT version that people have talked about for decades is telecommuting.”

It’s a “trend that’s worth exploring a lot more,” he’d added.

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Connie Loizos

Editor in Chief & General Manager |

Loizos has been reporting on Silicon Valley since the late '90s, when she joined the original Red Herring magazine. Previously the Silicon...

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Upwork pops more than 50 percent in Nasdaq debut

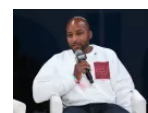
Danny Crichton — 8:46 AM PDT · October 3, 2018

Upwork, the rebranded merger of oDesk and Elance, debuted on Nasdaq this morning, after dropping its S-1 about four weeks ago. Shares opened at \$23.00, which represents a 53% jump — shares were priced at \$15 before the opening bell by investors, a significant uptick from the company's revised projection of \$12 to \$14, which was already an increase from its original \$10 to \$12 target. The stock trades under the ticker UPWK, and the company will fundraise approximately \$102 million of new cash for its balance sheet (\$187 million total with existing shareholders).

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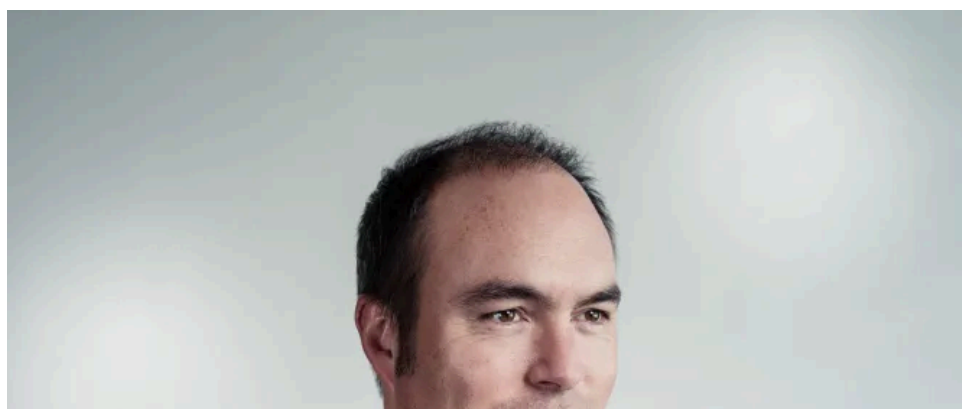
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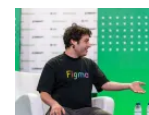
Shares are still currently up 40% compared to their original price.

I talked with Upwork CEO Stephane Kasriel this morning about the IPO road show, in which he said he took approximately 160 meetings with investors. Investors were engaged on the “combination of the strengths of the business and the strengths of the mission,” and he was clearly excited about the engagement the offering received.

Upwork, whose antecedent companies go back almost two decades, is a positive cash flow business, albeit one growing top line revenue only about 27.6% year over year. Kasriel said that the company should be able to “compound at that rate for decades” due to the growing number of workers who freelance around the world in order to have flexible work arrangements. “When you think about which jobs are being created in the global economy, in most countries it is these knowledge jobs,” he said.



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Figma’s IPO success is ‘a little bit of a meme stock,’ says Sapphire Ventures’ Jai Das

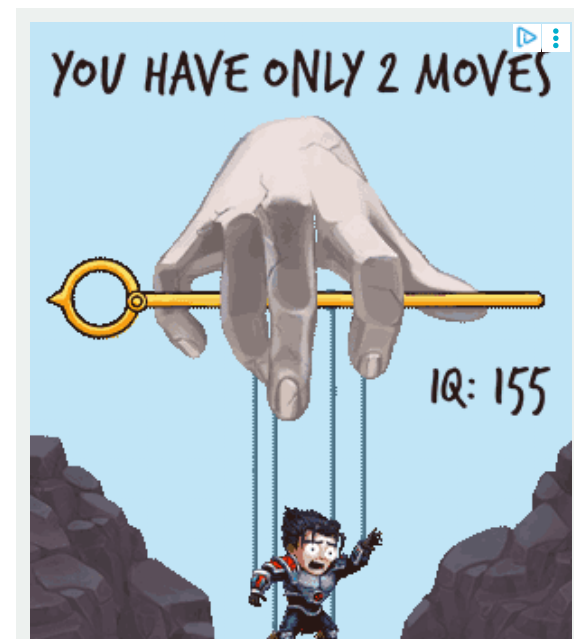
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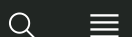


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As for Kasriel himself, he becomes a public company CEO. He was elevated to the CEO role in 2015 from SVP of Engineering – a somewhat unusual path, even in tech-obsessed Silicon

Valley. He emphasized that “we are a tech company,” and noted that every day is a learning experience. “I was just on CNBC, and for introverts, what really scares me is to be on live broadcast TV,” he said.

A huge part of Upwork’s business today is focused on the enterprise, particularly complex workflows that require multiple types of talent. The company’s platform not only handles talent management, but the long array of tasks to manage people: HR, legal, procurement, information security, and others.



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According to the company, it will host \$1.5 billion worth of gross sales value across two million unique projects. The company estimates that its products are used by 30% of the Fortune 500.

Upwork, which has offices in Mountain View, San Francisco, and Chicago, has 1,500 employees – and as is to be expected – roughly 1,100 of them are freelancers. Kasriel said, “We use our own product, which we call drinking our own champagne.”

Among the major VC investors behind the company are Benchmark, which owned 15%, Sigma Partners, which owned 14.2%, and Globespan, T. Rowe Price, and FirstMark. The company is offering 6,818,181 new shares as well as 5,658,512 shares from existing shareholders. Citigroup, Jefferies, and RBC jointly led the book.

Now that the company has debuted, Upwork wants to refocus once again on its business following weeks of talking to investors. “We need to build this company for the ages,” Kasriel noted, and said that his message to employees was to “focus on the mission.”



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 **Danny Crichton**
Contributor | [X](#)

Danny Crichton is an investor at [CRV](#) and a former contributing writer at TechCrunch.

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Freelance marketplace Upwork files to go public on Nasdaq as UPWK

Ingrid Lunden — 6:44 AM PDT · September 6, 2018

Another tech IPO is coming around the corner in what has been a strong year for startups taking the plunge and going public. [Upwork](#) — a marketplace connecting 375,000 freelance developers, writers, marketers and others with close to half a million clients — announced a plan to list on the Nasdaq exchange to trade under the ticker UPWK, [filing an S-1 form](#) with the SEC with initial financials and other details about the company.

Upwork's IPO is yet another mark of the bigger swing we've seen of privately-backed tech companies turning to the public markets for their next cash infusions for growth, this week alone seeing listings for [Elastic](#) and another freelancer behemoth, [Meituan in China](#).

The double-whammy of not one but two freelancer marketplaces (Meituan is more focused on services and tradespeople) underscores also the continuing growth of contractors as a key part of the labor force. There have been reports that [Fiverr](#), another freelancer platform, will also IPO by next year with a \$1 billion valuation (news perhaps timed to leak to offset Upwork's S-1).

But while freelance work provides a lot of flexibility to businesses in terms of how they scale up and down their workforces, and to people in terms of how they make money without being tied to a single job, it does not come without its

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own set of controversies. Not being tied to more traditional employment contracts gives those workers fewer employment rights and benefits, and it's been found that the fierce competition among marketplaces and workers has led to [lower wages overall](#). In that bigger race for more efficiency, Upwork itself has been in the spotlight for what appears to be invasive practices to make sure that their clients are getting their [money's worth](#) from workers, which hasn't helped the company's image.

So far, Upwork has not disclosed how much it intends to raise in the IPO, but its S-1 provides some details about the financials and other metrics of the company:

— In the 12 months that ended in June 2018, Upwork made \$228 million in revenues on Gross Services Value (GSV: the total amount of overall service work 'purchased' on its platform) of \$1.56 billion. Sales are currently growing at around 20 percent.

— The company, however, operates at a net loss, most recently posting \$7.1 million for the six months ending June 2018.

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— Upwork calls itself the largest global skilled freelancer marketplace. In the year that ended in June 2018, some 2 million projects were created on its platform engaging finance specialists, developers and designers, marketing specialists and writers of different kinds. It said it currently

has some 375,000 freelancers and 475,000 clients registered on its platform.

— Upwork said a whole 10 percent of its business comes from a single, unnamed client in the six months that ended June 2018. (It had two clients each accounting for 10 percent of its revenues in 2016 and 2017.)

— The company operates in 180 countries.

The news comes after [reports in July](#) of this year that Upwork

— [rebranded in 2015](#) after the merger of Elance and oDesk — had made a confidential filing to initiate the process.

Confidential filings is a route that many startups take in the first instance to start to sound out investors and begin the process of listing without as much public scrutiny.

The company most recently disclosed a valuation way back in 2014, when it was valued at around \$700 million. The cap table is not completely clear given its merged status.

According to Pitchbook, Upwork itself has only raised around \$30 million. Investors in the company include DAG Ventures, Benchmark Capital , T. Rowe Price, FirstMark Capital, Jackson Square Ventures, Globespan Capital Partners and Stripes Group.

Upwork said that part of the IPO proceeds will be used to pay back \$19 million of a loan made by Silicon Valley Bank.

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Ingrid was a writer and editor for TechCrunch, from February 2012 through May 2025, based out of London....

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